Indian users behave any differently during a viral trend.

During the Ghibli wave in 2025, Arjun D'Souza, senior legal counsel at the digital rights group SFLC, warned that users were quietly handing over biometric information that could be used to train future AI models. As he put it, 'much relating to AI outputs remains a black box,' since once your face is into its training data, there is no simple way to pull it back out.

Several Indian state cyber cells also issued similar public advisories during the same period. Reports also claim that Google Trends showed India among the top searching nations for Ghibli art, with Gujarat hitting the highest possible search score of 100.

Did you ever think that the biggest attraction of AI image tools is also one of their biggest concerns? You need to upload an original photo of yourself to get the desired output. What is important to note here is that the process is not done locally on your smartphone. The image is sent to a company's servers, where what happens to it next depends on the service's privacy policy, settings and data practices.

This isn't just about a photograph leaving your device as you do when you make it public by uploading it on social media. Still, things are more concerning than you realise, as a normal picture of you can reveal your face, location, surroundings, clothing, family members and sometimes other information stored in the original file. As we previously reported, photographs can contain metadata such as the time a picture was taken and GPS information, depending on the file and device.

While we do have a Digital Personal Data Protection Act, it says consent should be free, specific, informed and unambiguous, and users should be able to withdraw it. But do we have that liberty? The simple answer is NO.

Then there's another copyright angle. These tools recreate a distinct visual style built over decades by real animators at Studio Ghibli, without their consent or compensation, and the studio's own founder has publicly criticised AI animation in the past.

India's Copyright Act, 1957 recognises photographs as artistic works and generally identifies the photographer as the author of a photograph. Moreover, it also gives copyright owners rights over reproduction and adaptation of artistic works. But the law is grey, especially when it comes to AI tools. The government is moving fast, as a dedicated committee is currently under the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), but it may take some time.

AI images have also changed the relationship between a photograph and reality. For decades, people generally treated photographs as evidence that something happened, but that assumption is also becoming weaker now. An AI tool can now create a convincing picture of a person standing somewhere they have never been, wearing something they never wore or doing something they never did.

This becomes particularly serious in India, which is the world's most populous country, because images can spread rapidly through WhatsApp, Instagram, and other platforms. A misleading picture does not need to become a major news story to cause harm. It can circulate inside a family group, community or school before anyone checks whether it is real.



Scams nobody told you about

Deepfakes riding on this same tech have become a daily nuisance in India. McAfee's 2026 Scamiverse report found that Indians encounter about 4 deepfakes a day and 13 scam messages, spending 102 hours a year, nearly three working weeks, just trying to separate the real from the fake.

Not only that, but 51 per cent of Indians said they had lost money to a scam, with the average loss at Rs 93,915. A separate 2025 McAfee survey found 90 per cent of Indians had seen fake celebrity endorsements, while an earlier study showed 75 per cent had come across a deepfake, with a quarter of them seeing political deepfakes forwarded on WhatsApp and Telegram with no fact-checking.

The Indian government recognised the problem, and back in February 2026, the government amended the IT Rules to address harms linked to synthetically generated information, including AI content and deepfakes. Platforms are required to take reasonable technical measures against unlawful synthetic content and provide clear labelling and traceable information for permissible AI material.

Read more on Digit.in:
https://tinyurl.com/mjjy6ytk